Clash of Cultures, Strike and Superstition

There were strikes and protests in Bombay by native workers for better facilities such as better timings and hot water for bath. The English had clearly not foreseen this. But eventually, as the workers settled, the work proceeded smoothly.

The first Bombay contractors, William Fredrick Faviell and Henry Fowler, were experienced hands in England. They sailed to India on 19 December 1850. They got down to work immediately by employing nearly 10,000 workers, a largely rural workforce gathered from various neighbouring districts.

Invincible Prejudices

It was for the very first time that British engineers were dealing with native workers for a railway project. It was a clash of two cultures, with British engineers focussing on making the labour effective and the workers, in turn, demanding respect for their methods and religious practices.

Professor Ian J. Kerr, in his book *Building the Railways of the Raj: 1850-1900* , documents how a harried Mr Fowler shot off a letter on 2 May 1851 to his mentor in England stating that he had been trying to get the workers to start work at 6 a.m. instead of the customary 8 a.m., but ‘it is a most difficult thing to alter the existing system, as almost every custom the natives have is founded on absurd but invincible prejudices—generally of religious character’. [38]

Fowler lamented how the workers’ groups were divided into castes, affecting work, as they often would not work alongside men of other castes, and gives an example of how the workers had destroyed a vessel because Fowler had used it for a while. [39]

Rigid Work Practices

The *Bombay Quarterly Review* of July-October 1855 reports a strike by railway workers at the Coorla cutting for change in work timings so that they could take a hot water bath. It is not clear if this was the same episode that Fowler had been referring to and was reported by *The Review Magazine* . But the excerpts are indeed interesting!